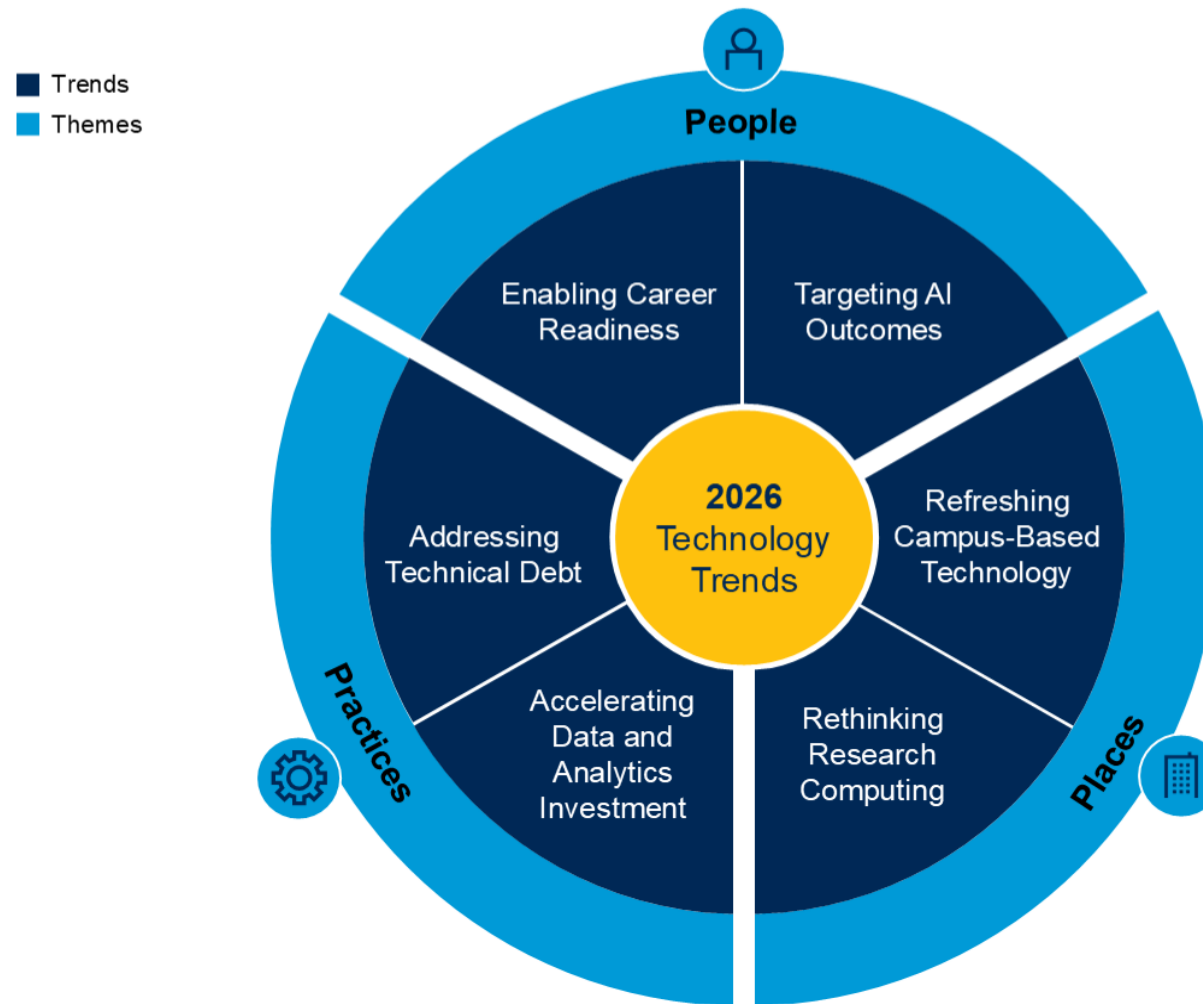




# Tarleton State University

Kristen Richardson

# Top Technology Trends in Higher Education for 2026



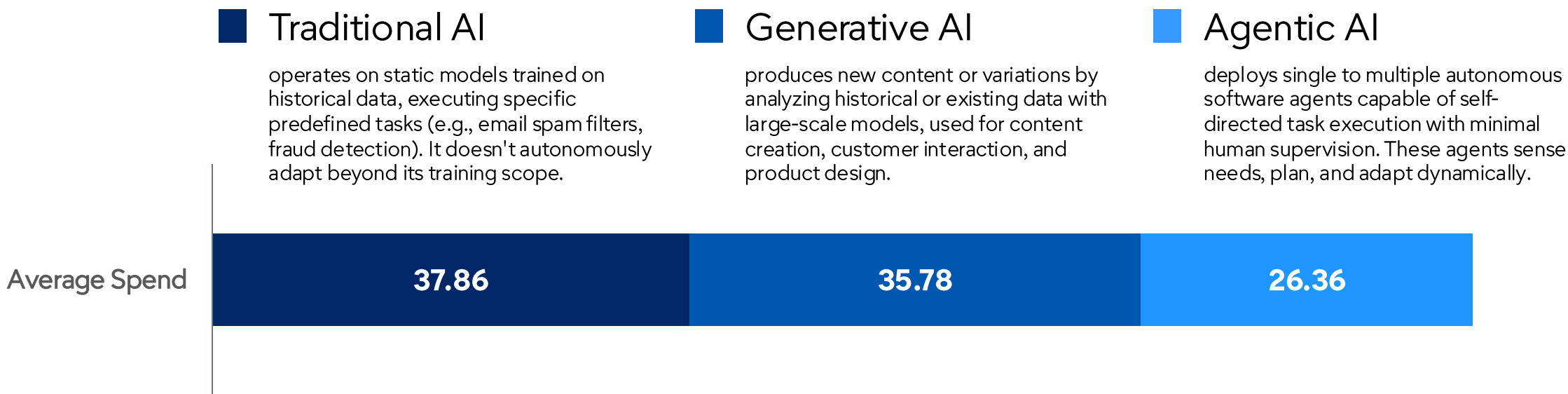
Source: Gartner  
840962

# Organizations Are Picking Their Pace



# Split of 2025 AI Spend Among Traditional, Generative and Agentic AI

Average functional AI spend

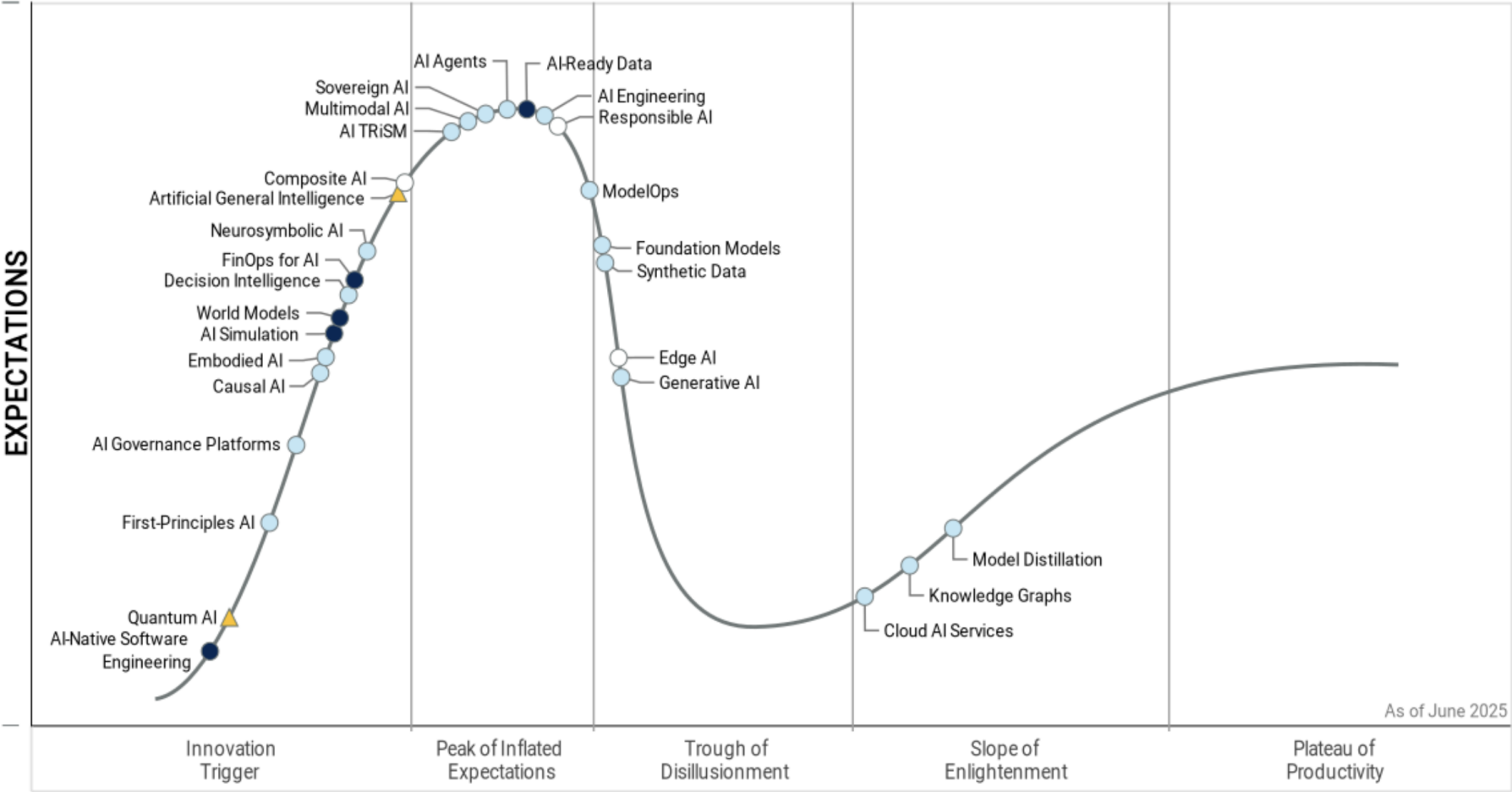


Despite Lower Share in 2025 Spend, **Agentic AI** is Expected to Be The Fastest-Growing AI Investment for Functions in 2026

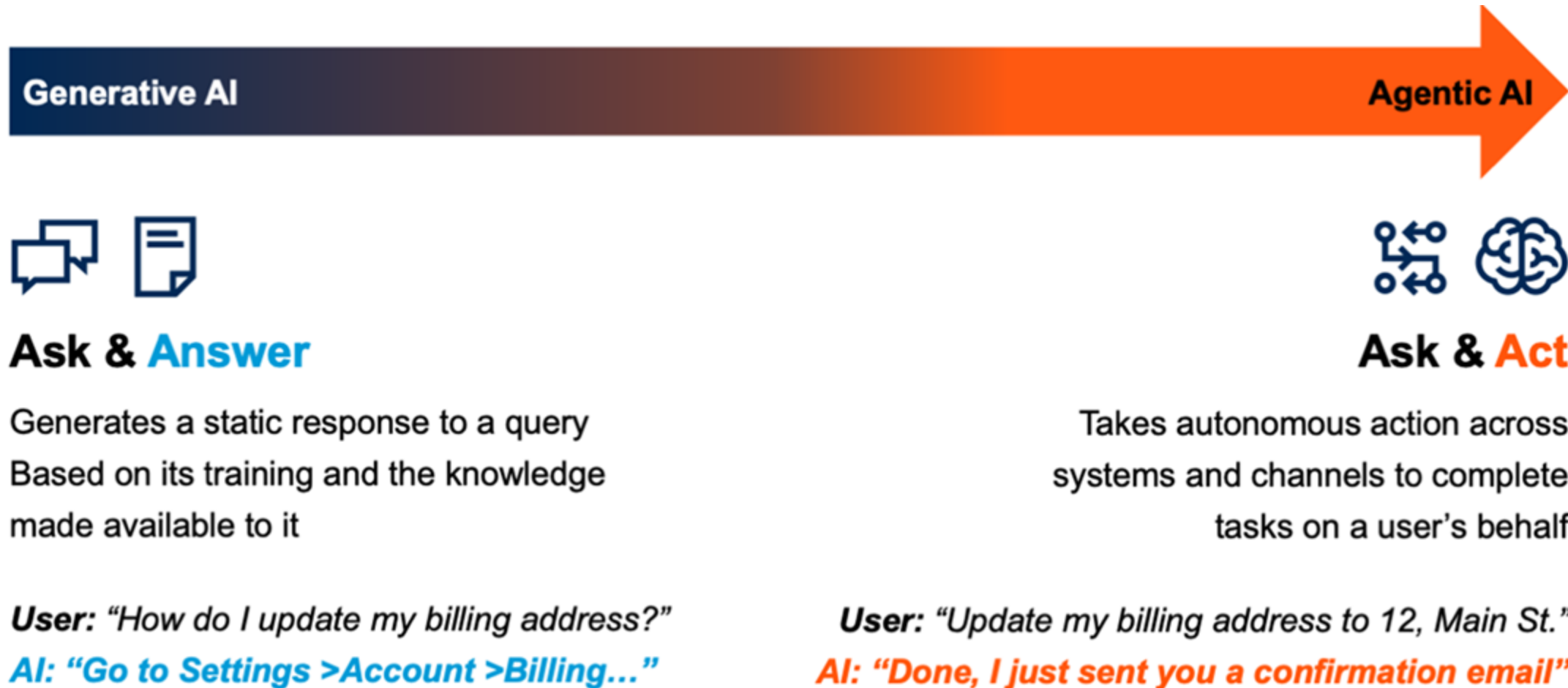
n = 1240, 1249, 1224 senior functional leaders across 10 business functions, excludes “don’t know”/ “We are not Planning to use this technology”  
Q06b1, Q06b2 , Q06b3 : For each of these technologies, by how much will your function increase or decrease funding in 2026 compared with 2025?  
Source: 2026 Gartner C-Suite AI Survey, conducted January-April 2026 among 1,303 senior functional leaders across 10 business functions. Fielded by Gartner using an external panel.

# Capabilities Are Moving Fast Along the AI Hype Cycle

Hype Cycle for Artificial Intelligence, 2025

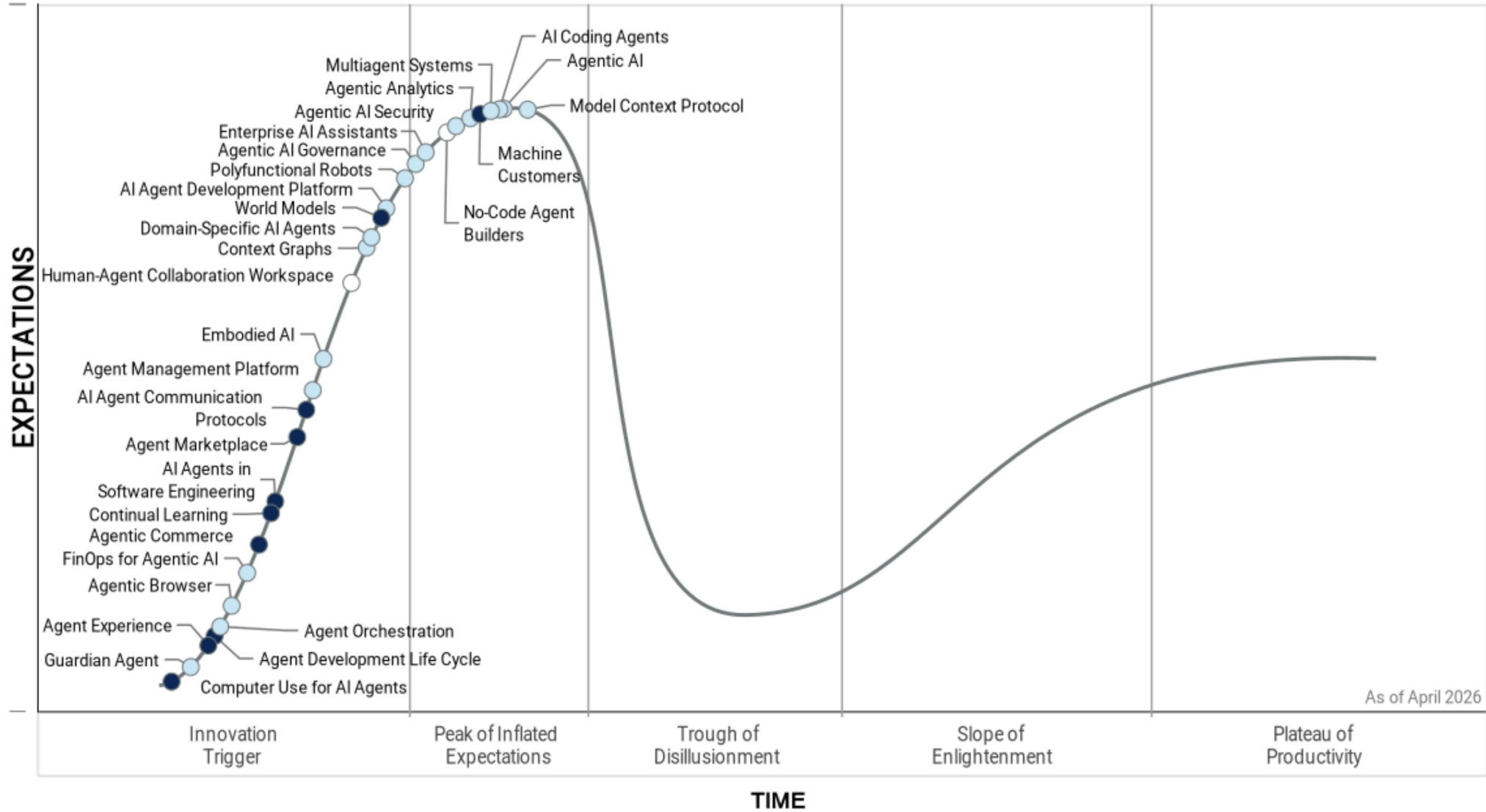


# The Evolution to Agentic AI is Moving Quickly



Source: [When to Use \(and When Not to Use\) Agentic AI for Customer Service](#)

# Hype Cycle for Agentic AI, 2026



Plateau will be reached: ○ <2 yrs. ● 2-5 yrs. ● 5-10 yrs. ▲ >10 yrs. ✗ Obsolete before plateau

# Leaders Pivot From Defend to Grow in 2026

## Focus is Clustering Around Three Mandates



Source: [CEO Watch Entering 2026: Confidence Is Muted, Resolution Is Heightened](#)

# Odds of Delivering Value to Meet Leadership Expectations

Based on past 2025 performances

**Odds of Initiative  
Success**

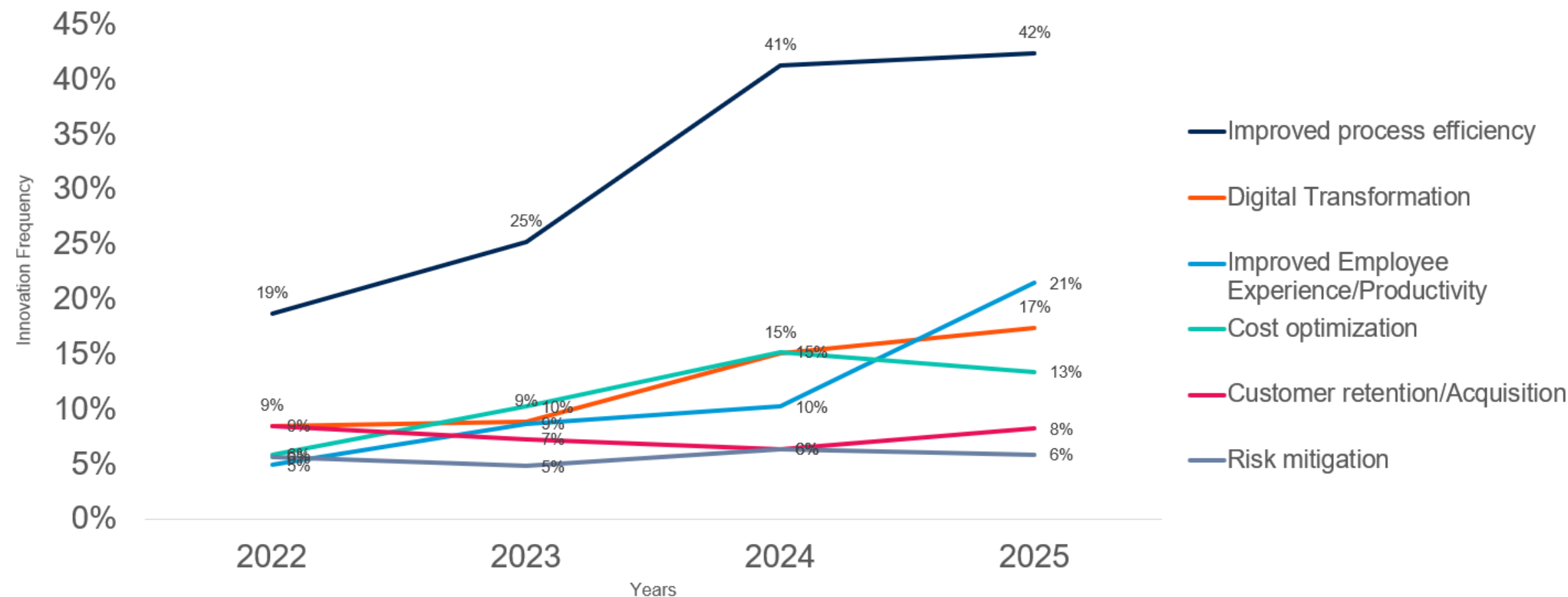
**1 in 5**

**Odds of Transformation  
Success**

**1 in 50**

Source: 2025 Gartner AI Survey: CIO and Technology Leader View

# Trends in AI-Driven Outcomes (%) by Year



n = Varies from 424 to 1284 for 2022 – 2025

Q: Provide and explain the quantitative/qualitative outcomes of your innovation.

Source: Gartner Eye on Innovation Awards  
840630

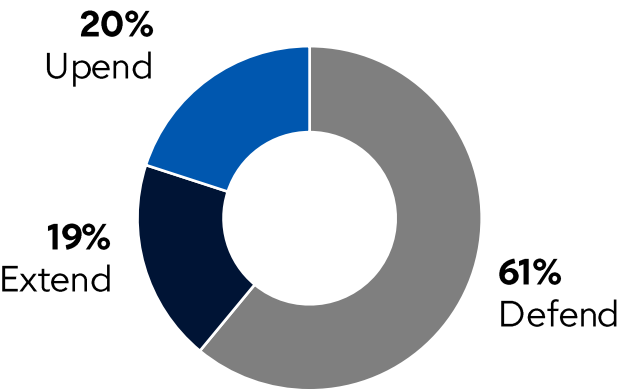
# AI Has Many Business Cases

|                                                                       | Everyday AI                                                                                                    |  | Game-changing AI                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                       | <div></div> <div>Defend</div> |  | <div></div> <div>Extend</div> | <div></div> <div>Upend</div> |
| Competitive ambition                                                  | Augment employees to maintain competitive parity                                                               |  | Financially improve enterprise for differentiation                                                               | Disrupt with new market/ public-facing models                                                                   |
| Examples                                                              | Save time, decide better                                                                                       |  | Reengineer, catch fraud, improve operations                                                                      | Discover and launch new prod/svc                                                                                |
| Expected return                                                       | <div>Return on Employee</div> <div>Good for employee &amp; operations</div>                                    |  | <div>Return on Investment</div> <div>Financial return</div>                                                      | <div>Return on Future</div> <div>Strategic bet</div>                                                            |
| Investment behavior                                                   | Non-financial value                                                                                            |  | Financial value                                                                                                  | Strategic value                                                                                                 |
| <div>Foundations (e.g. AI literacy, governance, data readiness)</div> |                                                                                                                |  |                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                 |

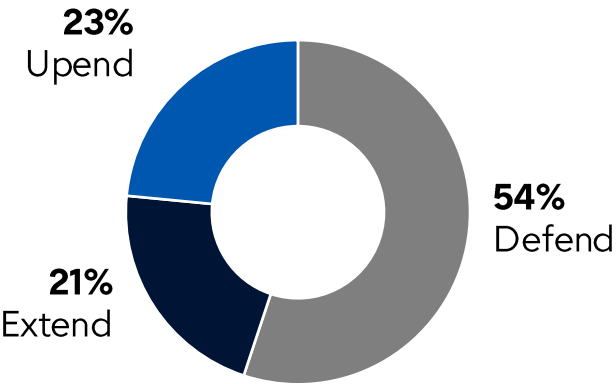
# Different Portfolios, Different Results

|               | Defend | Extend | Upend |                                                                                    |
|---------------|--------|--------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FOMO          | 80%    | 20%    | 0%    | Limited return, driven to deploy GenAI as fast as possible                         |
| Best Return   | 10%    | 80%    | 10%   | Most certain ROI, creates ability to differentiate                                 |
| Disruptor     | 20%    | 30%    | 50%   | Potential for dramatic industry change, requires large investment and long horizon |
| Limited Staff | 100%   | 0%     | 0%    | Lowest return, lowest staff deployment requirement                                 |

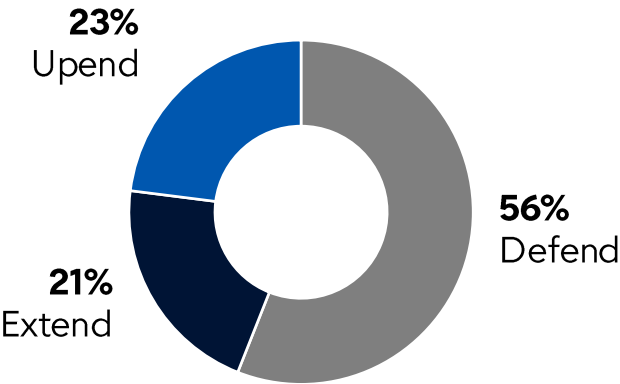
# Current Spend by Industry



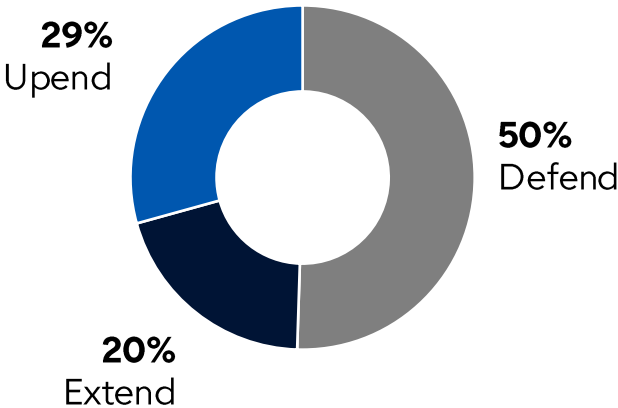
Financial services



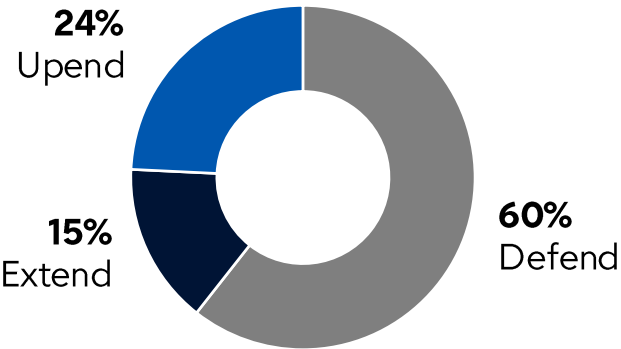
Education providers



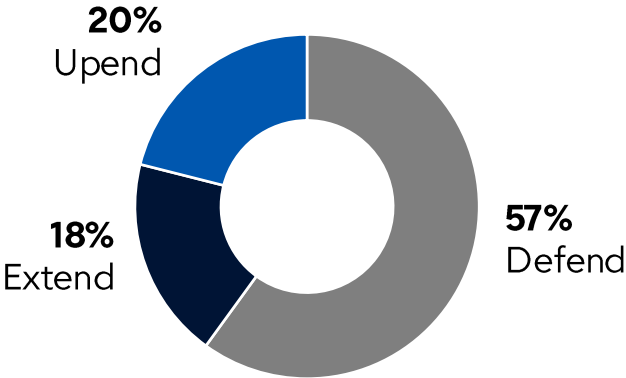
Energy/utilities



Government



Healthcare providers



Manufacturing

n = 394; all leaders whose organizations deployed at least one AI use case in production; excluding "not sure"; totals may not equal 100 due to rounding  
Q: Thinking about your organization's spending on AI initiatives, what percentage of that spend targets each of the following outcomes?  
Source: 2020 Gartner AI Maturity and Organizational Mandates Survey

# AI is Currently Moving Faster Than Organizations Can Change

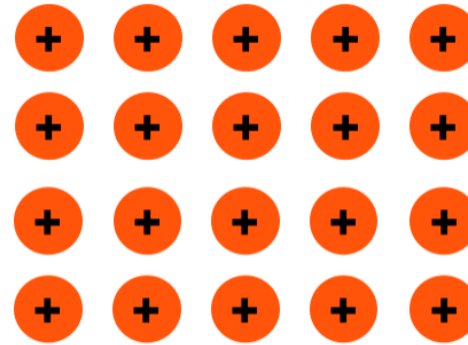
| Tier 1 | <br>AI strategy | <br>AI value | <br>AI organization | <br>AI people & culture | <br>AI governance | <br>AI engineering | <br>AI data |
|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tier 2 | Monitor and interpret AI trends                                                                    | Develop and manage AI use case portfolio                                                        | Develop external partnerships and alliances for AI                                                     | Manage culture and change for / due to AI                                                                  | Create, maintain, and evolve AI, governance policies and controls                                    | Design and architect AI applications and systems                                                      | Acquire and prepare AI data                                                                    |
|        | Develop and rationalize AI ambition                                                                | Develop AI value propositions and business cases                                                | Manage and balance internal and external ecosystem                                                     | Evolve roles and staffing for / due to AI                                                                  | Develop AI governance operating models and teams                                                     | Develop, test and integrate AI applications and systems                                               | Manage and govern AI data                                                                      |
|        | Develop and refine AI strategy                                                                     | Develop AI product portfolios                                                                   | Evolve internal operating model                                                                        | Deliver skills, training, and literacy for AI                                                              | Engineer oversight systems and enforce policies                                                      | Deploy, operate and scale AI systems                                                                  | Build AI data utilization and insights                                                         |
|        | Develop and coordinate AI strategic roadmap                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                      | Manage project, platform and application portfolios                                                   |                                                                                                |
|        | Innovate /                                                                                         |                                                                                                 |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                      | Develop and manage AI                                                                                 |                                                                                                |

# AI Job Transformation vs. AI Job Losses Organizational Effort



## AI Job Losses

Starting in 2028-2029,  
AI will **create more jobs**  
**than it eliminates.**



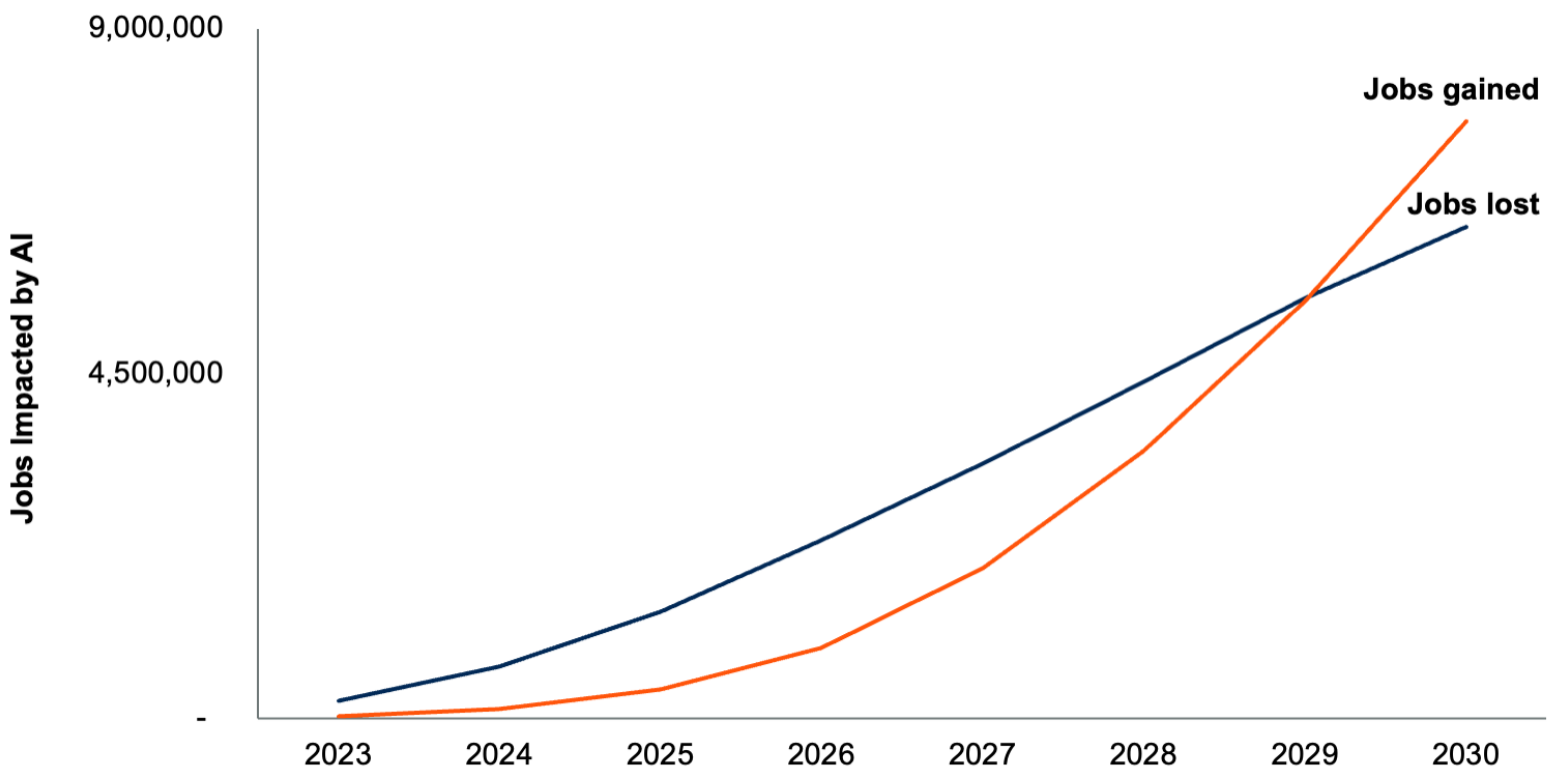
## AI Job Transformation

Over 32 million **will be transformed** each year  
due to AI, **requiring 20x more organizational**  
**effort** compared to AI job losses.

Source: Gartner  
842426

# Imminent Workforce Reshaping: AI Cumulative Job Impact Forecast

**AI Job Impacts Forecast**  
Running Total, Global<sup>a</sup>

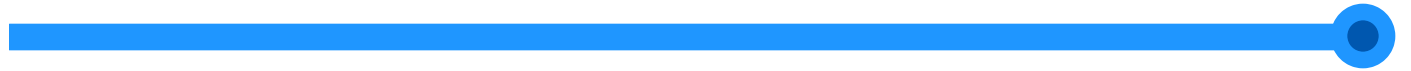


Source: Gartner  
<sup>a</sup> Global jobs, excluding China and India  
842426

In 2025, **20%** of IT work was done with the help of AI.

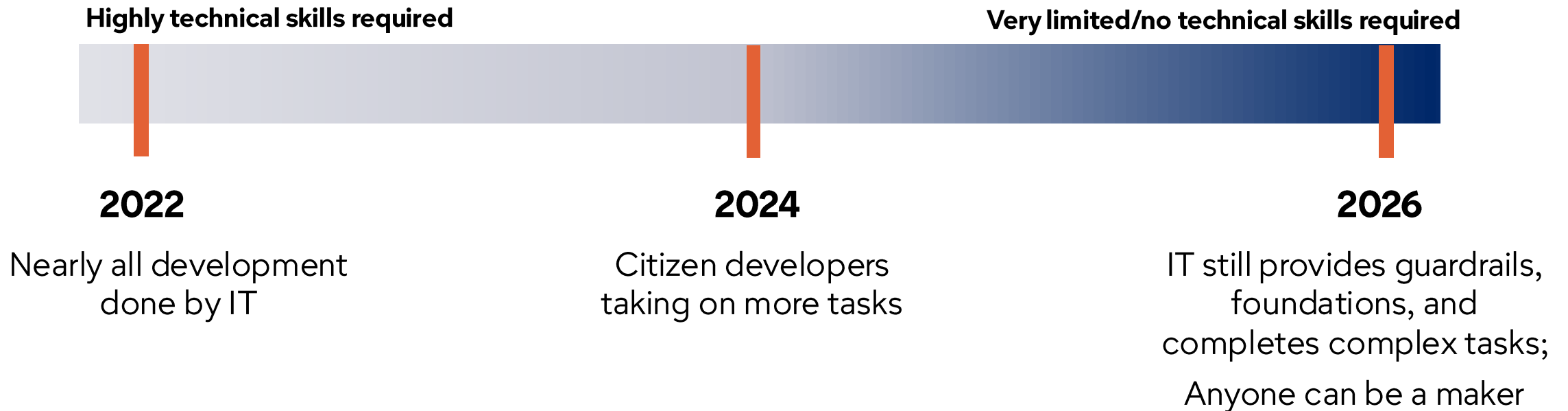


By 2030, **100%** of IT work will be done with the help of AI.



# The Technical Bar Has Shifted; Democratization Was Accelerated by AI

Simple front-end development is highly accessible





## Workforce transformers

AI leaders that address workforce transformation and talent are fully leveraging their other leadership capabilities

**4.3x**  
more effective

# How Can You React to Productivity Improvements?

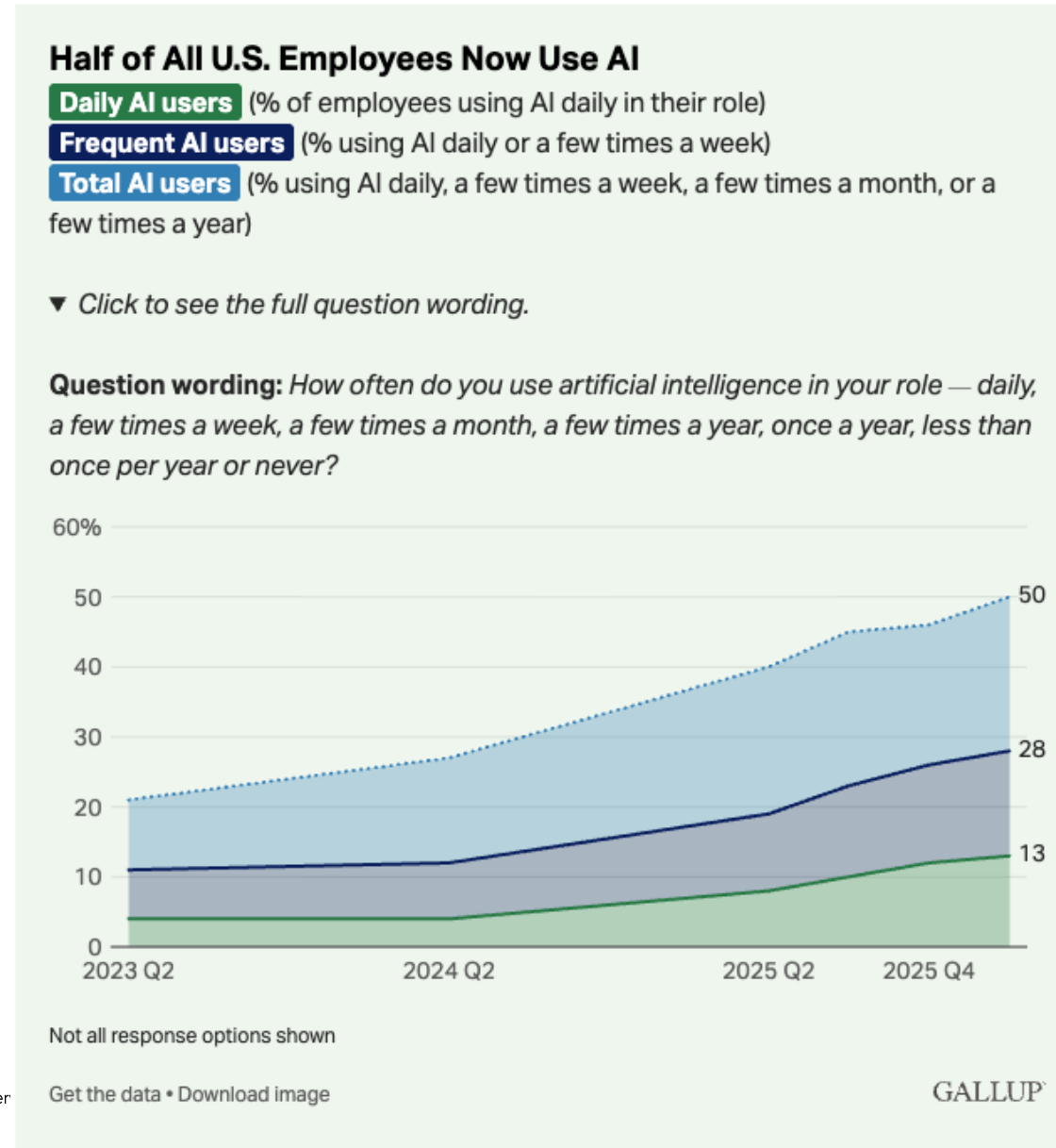
|             | Restrain                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Reduce                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Reposition                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What is it? | <p><b><i>Restrain hiring</i></b></p> <p><i>Freeze new hires, typically because existing staff with AI are doing the work typically performed by junior staff</i></p> <p>Example: Junior hiring reduction</p> | <p><b><i>Reduce headcount</i></b></p> <p><i>Layoff current staff typically because existing work can be done with AI, or staff significantly upskilled with AI</i></p> <p>Example: Contact Centres</p> | <p><b><i>Reposition FTEs</i></b></p> <p><i>Move human capital from low performing business lines or functions into net new AI revenue streams</i></p> <p>Example: Big Tech and some Professional Services</p> |
|             | Driven by Productivity                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Driven by Commerce                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| When is it? | <p><b>Now</b></p> <p><i>From 2025, and accelerating through 2027</i></p>                                                                                                                                     | <p><b>Not at scale yet</b></p> <p><i>From 2027</i></p>                                                                                                                                                 | <p><b>Now, in Big Tech especially</b></p> <p><i>From 2025 in select industries, and expanding to many industries by 2030</i></p>                                                                              |

# 12 AI Value Metrics for Key Enterprise Outcomes



Source: Gartner  
841975

# There is no doubt AI is transforming our ways of working



# AI Adoption = Workforce Transformation

27%

employees in AI-adopting organizations say that their workplace has changed in disruptive ways to a large or very large extent in the past year

18%

of all U.S. employees say it is very or somewhat likely their job will be eliminated within the next five years due to AI or automation

23%

among employees working in organizations that have adopted AI

Source: Gallup Q3 2025 Workforce studies

# AI has ushered in an era of “catalytic change”

## 2026 Change Management Trends and Implications

| 4 Change Trends that Will Shape Change Management in 2026                                                                |                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <br>Catalytic change changes everything | <br>Work changes quickly but unevenly | <br>AI becomes the vehicle for change, not the destination | <br>Change management increasingly focuses on opportunity |
| Implications to Take Action On                                                                                           |                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                              |
| Co-created change becomes a precious resource                                                                            | Work friction leads to change inertia                                                                                   | AI and change management strategy enhance each other                                                                                          | Change opportunity becomes a lever for talent management                                                                                     |
| “Unrequited change” threatens employee engagement                                                                        | Some employees will fail to adapt                                                                                       | Business challenges become AI opportunities                                                                                                   | Employees engage in “performative change compliance”                                                                                         |

Source: Gartner  
843594

60%

50%

# Prioritize AI Literacy to Maximize AI Value

AI literacy is the ability of people to effectively and responsibly utilize AI in their business context.

The current AI literacy of the organization should be assessed and the results used to design a training program that aligns to each persona group’s skills gaps.

## AI Literacy Competencies by Tier

Engineering Example

|                                             | 1                                                               | 2                                            | 3                                     | 4                                                     | 5                                                          |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                             | Core AI understanding                                           | Practical application                        | Data literacy                         | Ethics & governance                                   | Outcomes & evaluation                                      |
| Baseline<br>All engineers                   | Know when to and when not to use AI.                            | Use AI tools effectively in daily work.      | Know what data is safe to share.      | Recognize when to escalate concerns.                  | Judge if AI output is good enough.                         |
| AI engineers<br>Building AI-powered systems | Select appropriate AI technique/technology.                     | Build and integrate AI-powered features.     | Design data pipelines for AI systems. | Build compliant, responsible AI systems.              | Measure and monitor AI system performance.                 |
| Why                                         | Set realistic expectations; recognize when AI isn't the answer. | Build reliably; avoid becoming a bottleneck. | Prevent bias and compliance failures. | First line of defence; "should we" not just "can we." | Distinguish effective from ineffective; catch drift early. |

Source: Gartner  
843235

## CASE STUDY

# Lenovo's Principles to Help Managers Navigate Employee AI Resistance

| Potential Root Causes of Employee Resistance | Principles for Success                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Loss of identity or purpose.                 | <b>Explore identity shifts, not just task changes.</b> Surface how AI impacts your team's sense of purpose, not just their responsibilities.    |
| Emotional unease and feeling unheard.        | <b>Create space for emotional processing.</b> Practice active listening to respond with empathy, not just logic.                                |
| Loss of control over everyday work.          | <b>Surface emotional, not just workflow friction.</b> Look out for signals pointing to a loss of confidence or professional pride, not just UX. |
| Camouflaged anxiety and fear of judgment.    | <b>Build, don't assume psychological safety.</b> Normalize open dialogue by sharing uncertainties and fostering peer support.                   |
| Generic or overwhelming AI training.         | <b>Demystify AI through experiential, role-relevant learning.</b> Embed AI learning into their day-to-day work.                                 |

# Make Managers AI Storytellers

“Managers are uniquely positioned to inspire employees, reinforce culture, surface potential barriers and help us capture AI value. As catalysts for AI transformation, managers need dedicated support to lead through AI change.”

— Linda Yao, Vice President & General Manager, Hybrid Cloud & AI Solutions, Lenovo

## AI Value Stories Library

### Illustrative

| If you observe                 | Don't just explain the AI benefit           | Make your value story about                                                                              | Support your story with metrics                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Time savings                   | "Developers on my team save 6 hours a week" | "Our team of 10 now delivers work equivalent of an 11.5 person team"                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• % increase in team output</li><li>• Cost avoidance</li></ul>                                |
| Improved decision-making speed | "Reduced our decision cycle time by 40%"    | "We are able to accelerate time-to-market and capture early-mover advantages"                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Time-to-market</li><li>• No. Of decisions implemented</li></ul>                             |
| Reduced manual work            | "We've automated 40% of repetitive tasks"   | "We've increased the share of work that requires human judgment, boosting team engagement and value-add" | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• % of tasks requiring human discretion</li><li>• Task complexity index</li></ul>             |
| Fewer errors                   | "Error rates dropped by 20%"                | "We're building trust by getting things right the first time and reducing downstream rework"             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• % of work passing first-time quality checks</li><li>• Rework-to-output ratio</li></ul>      |
| Improved forecast accuracy     | "Forecast variance is down 15%"             | "We're reducing last-minute fire drills by proactively adjusting plans"                                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• % of plans adjusted pre-deadline</li><li>• # Of last-minute escalations avoided</li></ul>   |
| Faster reporting               | "Reports are generated 2x faster"           | "We're shortening the time from insight to action, enabling faster pivots"                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• % of decisions made within 24 hours of reporting</li><li>• Insight-to-action time</li></ul> |
| Increased output volume        | "We've increased throughput by 25%"         | "We're hitting stretch goals without increasing headcount"                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Output per team hour</li><li>• % of stretch goals achieved</li></ul>                        |

# Plan for Teams and Roles Based on Your Desired Pace

## Work through each function:

- Determine the target state for each function.
- Establish training, transition and reskilling plans.